1 Evidence Lab

Measure the footprint, convert it, cross one off · You hand out: **CLUE 1** envelopes

THE WHOLE STORY, FOR YOU

Yesterday afternoon the class's Party Candy Jar vanished from the high shelf. Four suspects: the Principal, the Reading Specialist, the Librarian, the Custodian. Four stations, one clue each, and every clue clears one suspect. Between rotations the kids hear from a suspect on video. By the end all four are crossed off, the kids realize their list was too short, and the Chief, Mrs. Driscoll herself, turns out to be the thief. The jar was never candy either: it was squishies, which the kids find hidden around the room with blacklights at the finale. Your part: run your activity your way, keep your clue a surprise until it comes out, and hand over the sealed envelope at the bell. The squads work out what it means on their own.

YOUR TABLE

A painted footprint was found by the shelf. The kids measure it in centimeters, look it up on the shoe-size chart (26 cm = size 9), write the size in their case file, then look at the suspect table and cross off whoever isn't a 9. That's the whole station. Let them measure as many times as they like.

AN OPENING LINE, IF YOU WANT ONE

"Every footprint tells a story. Let's find out what size our thief wears."

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER

- They leave with: **26 cm = size 9**, written on the Evidence Lab line of their case file.
- Keep the chart face down until they have a number.
- Then the cross-off: have them find the one suspect who isn't a size 9 and draw a line through them.

HOW YOUR CLUE FITS THE CASE

The footprint is the thief's: a size 9. Every suspect gave a shoe size. The Principal, the Reading Specialist and the Custodian are all 9s. The Librarian is a 7. When a squad opens CLUE 1 and checks the suspects, **the Librarian is cleared**.

The Chief is a size 9 too, which is how the kids catch her at the end. Don't bring her up.

Until the first video plays (about 1:50) everyone calls it the candy jar; after that the kids know it was squishies. Follow their lead. Never say who did it.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 1 envelope, unopened. Flip the chart face down again.

On your table: the footprint under a plastic sheet, rulers, the shoe-size chart (face down), pencils, four CLUE 1 envelopes.

2 Ghostbuster Lab

Fizz the ghosts, find the words · You hand out: **CLUE 2** envelopes

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YOUR TABLE

Five baking-soda ghosts sit in a bin, each hiding a laminated word. The kids squirt them with green vinegar from syringes until they fizz apart, pull out the words and arrange them into a sentence: SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15. One ghost per kid works well; if someone wants to share or go twice, fine.

AN OPENING LINE, IF YOU WANT ONE

"These ghosts are holding evidence hostage. The only thing they can't survive is vinegar. Bust them."

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER

- They leave with: **SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15**, one word in each of the five boxes in their case file.
- Don't say the time before the ghosts do. The reveal is the whole point of your table.
- Sleeves up, vinegar stays in the bin, five fresh ghosts for each group.

HOW YOUR CLUE FITS THE CASE

Your ghosts say WHEN it happened. Until a squad reaches you, nobody knows the time; the case file only says "yesterday afternoon." The Principal's statement says he was off campus at a meeting from 1:00 to 3:00, so he can't be the one seen in the hall at 2:15. CLUE 2 says the same, and **the Principal is cleared**.

The other three suspects were all in the building at 2:15. So was the Chief, in her classroom.

Until the first video plays (about 1:50) everyone calls it the candy jar; after that the kids know it was squishies. Follow their lead. Never say who did it.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 2 envelope, unopened. Scoop the mush into the bin, wipe the table, set out five fresh ghosts.

On your table: a tablecloth with a big plastic bin on it, 25 ghosts in muffin tins (5 per group), a pitcher of green vinegar, 6 syringes, paper towels and wipes, four CLUE 2 envelopes.

3 The Cipher Room

Decode the note, find the hidden message · You hand out: **CLUE 3** envelopes



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YOUR TABLE

The thief left a ransom note in a symbol code. The squad decodes it with the key (YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT), then sweeps the page with a blacklight and a hidden line glows: SNAGGED SOMETHING ORANGE ON THE SHELF. WORTH IT. Work it however you like; give hints when they stall. Extra time: kids write secret messages in symbols on the take-home cards.

> **AN OPENING LINE, IF YOU WANT ONE**
> "The thief left a note and thinks we can't read it. Prove them wrong. Then look at the paper again. Thieves always leave something behind."

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER

- They leave with: the hidden P.S. about **something orange**, written on the Cipher Room lines of their case file.
- Hold the blacklight back until the note is decoded. The glowing line is the payoff.
- Take the key back at the bell. The notes stay with you.

HOW YOUR CLUE FITS THE CASE

The decoded note is a taunt. The glowing P.S. is the evidence. The thief snagged something orange on the shelf, so the thief was wearing orange. The Principal, the Reading Specialist and the Librarian all wore orange for Halloween week. The Custodian wore a gray work shirt. CLUE 3 says the same, and **the Custodian is cleared**.

The Chief wore orange too. Your blacklight returns at the finale: the hidden squishy tags glow the same way.

Until the first video plays (about 1:50) everyone calls it the candy jar; after that the kids know it was squishies. Follow their lead. Never say who did it.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 3 envelope, unopened. Take the key back.

On your table: four ransom notes, the symbol key, pencils, two blacklight flashlights, a stack of take-home message cards, four CLUE 3 envelopes.

4 The Mummy Witness

Wrap a mummy, send it to the witness box · You hand out: **CLUE 4** envelopes



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YOUR TABLE

The only witness is a mummy, and mummies only talk to mummies. Each squad wraps one of their own in toilet paper against a 90-second timer, and the mummy hobbles to the witness box to fetch the witness statement. The clue is printed inside the box lid and at the bottom of the statement, so it can't be missed. Second mummy if there's time; a time to beat is always popular.

> **AN OPENING LINE, IF YOU WANT ONE**
> "I am the witness. I saw everything. But I only speak to mummies. You have ninety seconds. Make me one."

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER

- They leave with: **squishies**, on the Mummy Witness line of their case file. Whoever took the jar REALLY likes squishies.
- Eyes and mouth stay uncovered. Everything torn off goes straight into the trash bag.
- Only the mummy opens the box. That's the rule, and the kids will enforce it for you.

HOW YOUR CLUE FITS THE CASE

The witness says the thief REALLY likes squishies. Three suspects admitted they love them. The Reading Specialist wrote DON'T GET THEM, and says so in the video. CLUE 4 says the same, and **the Reading Specialist is cleared**.

The Chief's own form says "Fine. Love them." Squads arriving before about 1:50 still think the jar held candy; the statement works either way, and they catch up at the next video.

Until the first video plays (about 1:50) everyone calls it the candy jar; after that the kids know it was squishies. Follow their lead. Never say who did it.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 4 envelope, unopened. Put out four fresh rolls.

On your table: 20 rolls of cheap toilet paper, a stopwatch, trash bags, a tape line on the floor and the witness box ten feet away (clue inside the lid, four identical statements inside), four CLUE 4 envelopes.

FL

Floater / Photographer

Door, badges, restocks, photos, the hidden tags

Arrive 1:00 · Whole party



Before 1:30

- Crime-scene tape on the door frame (door stays usable). LED candle at each station.
- Cauldron and the Evidence Locker (under a cloth) by the Chief's desk.
- Spare badges and the 4 case files on the door table.

Timeline

1. **1:30** Door: kids wear the badge they filled in at training (1 purple, 2 black, 3 teal, 4 orange); spare badges and the squad list for anyone whose badge went missing. Each squad gets its numbered case file. Point each squad to the station with its number.
2. **1:38 to 2:28** Rotations: bathroom runs in pairs, restock stations (TP, vinegar, wipes), photos of each station (check the opt-out list first).
3. **Each bell:** dim the lights while the Detective plays the video; back up to "dim" when it ends.
4. **Rotation 3 (2:04):** hide the 20 highlighter-marked evidence tags around the room: under desks, inside books, under chairs. Nobody notices; they're busy.
5. **2:28** Deliberation: lights up. Snacks by squad if food is approved. Open the Wanted Poster table. Collect warrants into the cauldron. (The Detective handles the Chief's statement form.)
6. **2:40** Warrants read, Video 4 plays. Hand 3 blacklight flashlights to each squad. Stand by the lit hallway door during lights-out.
7. **2:48** Lights up. The Chief brings the Jar out. You run the trade: one tag, one squishy (candy layer first if there is one).
8. **2:55** Group photo with badges. Strike stations with the leads. Trash out. Tablecloths rolled and tossed.

Bin

- Spare badges (4 colors), 4 case files (one per squad)
- Spare TP, spare wipes, trash bags
- 20 evidence tags (highlighter-marked)
- 12 blacklight flashlights
- The EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy (goes to the Detective before 1:30)
- Camera or phone, photo opt-out list
- Squad list from the Chief

The one thing that can't slip

The 20 tags must be hidden before 2:40. If rotation 3 gets away from you, hide them during rotation 4.

You are the only adult without a station. Everyone will ask you for things.

DET

The Detective's cue card

Opening, the live beat after Video 1, the finale lines



Room parent | Trench coat, clipboard

1:30 · THE OPENING (LIGHTS OFF, 90 SECONDS MAX)

"Detectives, we have a situation. Sometime yesterday afternoon, the Party Candy Jar, the one you have been staring at for a week, disappeared from that shelf. We don't know when. Yet. The door was locked. The window was shut. Somebody on this staff knows something. We have four suspects. Three of them have recorded statements, and you'll hear from them as the investigation unfolds. The fourth, the Custodian, declined to comment. Make of that what you will. We have four pieces of evidence, and exactly one hour before the trail goes cold. Your squad has a case file. Fill it in. Clear the innocent and you'll know who did it. Chief _____ has assured me she is not a suspect. Let's begin."

1:49 · RIGHT AFTER VIDEO 1 (THE PRINCIPAL)

Let the room react for five seconds. Then: "Did... did the Principal just say squishies?" Reach into the coat. Pull out the EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy. "Recovered from under that shelf this morning. I assumed it was unrelated." Turn to the Chief. "Chief. What exactly was in that jar?" *The Chief, flustered: "Candy. ...Mostly. Candy-adjacent."* Back to the room: "Detectives. That jar was never candy. Open your case files. Cross out 'candy.' Write 'squishies.' This changes nothing about the evidence and everything about the motive. Rotate."

2:02 AND 2:15 · AFTER VIDEOS 2 AND 3

One line each, then the bell. "The Reading Specialist does not understand squishies. Noted. Rotate." / "Check their feet. Hm. Rotate."

2:28 · THE FIFTH STATEMENT

The first squad to say "everyone's crossed off" gets it said for the room: "Then your list is too short. Four clues: size 9, in the building at 2:15, wore orange, loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" Let them guess. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect." You: "Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." Pin it to the board next to the other four and read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous." "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

2:40 · WARRANTS AND THE FINAL STATEMENT

Pull each warrant from the cauldron and read it aloud: "Squad 1 accuses... the Chief." The Chief protests: "This is outrageous. I'm the Chief." You: "There is one more statement. It was recorded under protest." Play Video 4. When it ends: "Detectives, you heard her. A very special light. In one minute the lights go out for three minutes. Flashlights to the squads. Every detective finds one tag. Then we open the Jar."